

The Mountain — Game Design Document

1. Concept

The Mountain is a 2–4 player competitive deck-building race game. Players are mountaineers competing to be the first to reach The Summit (elevation 19). Each player builds a personal deck of tools, skills, and supplies over the course of the game while navigating terrain hazards, weather events, wildlife encounters, and other climbers. The mountain is a vertical track of 20 location cards — some hidden until explored — each with its own terrain, challenge slots, and capacity limits.

Core tension: Do you push higher now (risking challenges you might not beat) or hang back to build a stronger deck?

Player count: 2–4

Win condition: First player to reach The Summit (elevation 19) wins immediately.

2. Visual Design Identity

2.1 Aesthetic Philosophy

The visual language is a **handmade field journal** – as if the game materials were assembled from an experienced alpinist's expedition notes, hand-drawn maps, and dog-eared equipment tags. Everything feels tactile, slightly imperfect, and warm. The mountain is not a

digital game board; it is a surveyor's sketch come to life.

Key qualities:

- **Organic imperfection** – rounded corners are never identical on all four sides, borders have slight rotation and variation
- **Warm paper tones** – cream, tan, and ink rather than black/white or neon
- **Handwritten typography** – casual but legible, not precious
- **Sketch-line borders** – cards and panels have a visible inner border slightly offset from the outer one, evoking ruled field notes
- **Physical metaphors** – buttons feel like they can be pressed

(translate down on active), cards have paper grain

2.2 Color Palette

Paper & Ink (base surfaces)

Name	Hex	Use
<code>--paper</code>	<code>#f0e6cf</code>	Primary surface / card face
<code>--paper-2</code>	<code>#f5eedb</code>	Elevated surface, button rest state
<code>--paper-deep</code>	<code>#e7d9b8</code>	Recessed areas, button hover
<code>--paper-edge</code>	<code>#dac9a2</code>	Panel edges, shadows
<code>--ink</code>	<code>#332f28</code>	Primary text, lines, outlines
<code>--ink-mid</code>	<code>#6a6151</code>	Secondary text, subdued labels
<code>--ink-faint</code>	<code>#9b9079</code>	Placeholder text, disabled states

Line & Border

Name	Value	Use
--line	rgba(51,47,40,.55)	Default border
--line-soft	rgba(51,47,40,.28)	Inner border, subtle dividers

Player Colors

Character	Hex	Tone
You (P1)	#3c6c9c	Steel blue
Doctor	#5f7e44	Olive green
Alpinist	#bd5638	Burnt orange
Glaciologist	#cf9a32	Warm gold

Signal Colors

Name	Hex	Use
<code>--gold</code>	<code>#cf9a32</code>	Summit flag, rewards, accent
<code>--ice</code>	<code>#7ba6c6</code>	Ice terrain, cold indicators
<code>--ice-deep</code>	<code>#4d7ea6</code>	Active ice elements
<code>--danger</code>	<code>#9e3a2c</code>	Fail states, red alerts
<code>--camp</code>	<code>#6f8b46</code>	Camp markers, safe passage

Mountain Illustration Palette

Element	Hex
Background (page)	<code>#e7d9b8</code>
Mountain body	<code>#ece3cc</code>
Snow peak	<code>#f6f3ea</code>
Outlines / strokes	<code>#332f28</code>
Summit flag	<code>#cf9a32</code>

2.3 Typography

All fonts evoke hand-lettering and field documentation:

Variable	Family	Use
--hand	"Patrick Hand", "Comic Sans MS", cursive	Headings, labels, buttons – primary voice
--script	"Caveat", cursive	Flavor text, callouts, italicized notes
--serif	"Spectral", Georgia, serif	Body text, long descriptions
--mono	"Spline Sans Mono", ui-monospace	Stats, numbers, elevation markers

Heading style: `--hand` at 400 weight,
letter-spacing `0.02em`
Label style: `--hand` uppercase,
letter-spacing `0.06em`
Body text: `--serif` for card
descriptions and rules text

2.4 Paper Grain Texture

All surfaces use a subtle paper grain overlay to reinforce the physical material feel:

- Two overlapping radial-gradient dot patterns at offset positions (7px/7px and 13px/13px)
 - Dot color: `rgba(120,100,60,.05)` and `rgba(120,100,60,.04)`
 - Creates a very subtle woven-paper appearance without looking digital
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2.5 Sketch-Box Component (Cards & Panels)

The core container component in the UI – used for mountain location cards, hand cards, info panels, and modals.

Outer border:

- 1.5px solid `var(--line)`
- Border-radius varies per corner:
`11px 9px 12px 8px / 9px 12px 8px 11px`
- Box shadow: `1px 2px 0`
`rgba(51,47,40,.10), inset 0 0 0 1px`
`rgba(255,255,255,.25)`

Inner border (via `::after` pseudo-element):

- Inset 3px from all edges
- 1px solid `var(--line-soft)`
- Slightly different corner radii than outer: `9px 11px 7px 10px / 11px`

8px 12px 7px

- Creates the "notebook ruled box" double-border effect

This dual-border system is what makes containers feel hand-drawn rather than digitally rendered.

2.6 Button System

Buttons are styled as hand-stamped labels.

Rest state:

- Font: `--hand`, 16px, uppercase, letter-spacing `0.04em`
- Background: `var(--paper-2)` (`#f5eedb`)
- Border: 1.5px solid `var(--line)`
- Border-radius: `9px 7px 10px 6px / 7px 10px 6px 9px` (organically varied)

- Shadow: `1px 2px 0 rgba(51,47,40,.18)`
– slight bottom-right offset like a rubber stamp

Hover: Background shifts to `var(--paper-deep)` (`#e7d9b8`)

Active (pressed):

- `transform: translate(1px, 2px)` – physically pushes down
- Shadow drops to zero – sells the press-down feel

Disabled: Opacity 0.4, cursor not-allowed, no shadow

Variants:

- `.btn-primary` – dark fill: background `#332f28`, text `var(--paper)` – for primary actions (submit push)
- `.btn-danger` – red text `var(--danger)` (`#9e3a2c`), red border –

for destructive/retreat actions

2.7 Modal / Overlay

Challenge and action modals use a scrim layer:

- Full-viewport fixed overlay
 - Background: `rgba(40, 34, 24, .55)`
 - Backdrop blur: 1.5px – softens the board behind the modal
 - Content enters with `fadein` animation
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2.8 Animations

All animations emphasize organic, physical movement:

Name	Duration	Effect	Us
<code>fadein</code>	0.5s ease	<code>opacity: 0,</code> <code>translateY(6px)</code>	Pa re

Name	Duration	Effect	Us
		→ normal	ca
pop	0.35s cubic-bezier(.2, 1.4, .4, 1)	opacity: 0, scale(.85) → normal	Mo en re in
float-up	—	Up 26px + fade out	Go ga sc po
drift	loop	±3px vertical bob	Id to su

2.9 Mountain Illustration (Board Background)

The game board background depicts a stylized mountain cross-section as a flat graphic, not a photograph:

Structure:

- Main mountain body: triangle `M180 700 L600 150 L1020 700`, fill `#ece3cc`, 6px dark-brown stroke
- Snow-capped peak: irregular polygon starting at `600,150`, fill `#f6f3ea`, 5px stroke
- Atmospheric depth: three curved topographic contour lines at decreasing opacity (0.35, 0.70, 0.55) – width 3px each – suggesting layered terrain
- Climbing route: quadratic bezier curve from lower slope to summit, dashed `stroke-dasharray="2 16"`, opacity 0.6
- Summit flag: vertical pole with banner shape, colored `#cf9a32` (gold), 6px stroke

The illustration sits in the background of the board area and

gives context to the location cards stacked above it.

2.10 Scrollbar Styling

Custom scrollbars maintain the aesthetic:

- Width/height: 10px
 - Thumb: `var(--line-soft)`, 6px radius, 2px transparent border with `background-clip: padding-box`
 - Hover: `var(--line)` (slightly darker)
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3. Mountain Board

3.1 Structure

The mountain is a linear track of **20 location cards** (elevation 0–19) displayed vertically with The Summit

at the top. Cards are revealed progressively as players move up – unrevealed cards show only a topographic-hatching pattern and "Unexplored" label.

3.2 Location Cards (All 20)

Each card has: name, terrain type, player capacity, number of challenge slots, and whether a camp may be placed there.

Elev	Name	Terrain	Spaces	Chall
0	Base Camp Alpha	mixed	4	0
1	Gravel Flats	rock	4	1
2	Birch Forest Approach	mixed	4	1

Elev	Name	Terrain	Spaces	Chall
3	Boulder Field	rock	4	2
4	The Scree Slope	rock	4	1
5	Frozen Creek Crossing	ice	4	2
6	Lower Glacier	ice	4	1
7	Crevasse Field	crevasse	3	2
8	Ice Wall Base	ice	3	1
9	Exposed Ridge	rock	3	2
10	The Couloir	snow	3	1
11	High Camp Plateau	snow	3	0

Elev	Name	Terrain	Spaces	Chall
12	Windward Face	snow	3	2
13	Cornice Approach	snow	3	2
14	Death Zone Entry	ice	2	1
15	The Seracs	ice	2	2
16	Final Ridge	snow	2	1
17	The Headwall	rock	2	2
18	Pre-Summit Snowfield	snow	2	1
19	The Summit	summit	1	0

3.3 Terrain Types

Terrain	Description	Dominant Zone
mixed	Forested approaches, gravel, varied ground	Lower mountain (0–2)
rock	Exposed rock, boulder fields, ridges	Lower-mid (1–4, 9, 17)
ice	Glaciers, ice walls, death zone	Mid-upper (5–6, 8, 14–15)
snow	High-altitude snowfields, cornices	Upper (10–13, 16, 18)
crevasse	Glacier fractures, void crossings	Mid (7)
summit	The peak	Top (19)

3.4 Capacity Squeeze

Player capacity on location cards decreases with altitude:

- Elevations 0–6: **4 spaces**
- Elevations 7–13: **3 spaces**
- Elevations 14–18: **2 spaces**
- Elevation 19: **1 space**

A full location cannot be entered unless the player initiates a **Jostle**.

4. Player Characters (Backgrounds)

Players choose a background at setup, which determines their starting stats, hand size, gold, camp capacity, a unique ability, and one bonus starter card.

Mountaineer

Expert technical climber. Dominates rock and ice but neglects recovery.

- **Stats:** +3 str, +2 agi, -2 sur, -1 warm
- **Ability – Sure-Footed:** Terrain challenge falls become "discard 1" instead of falling.
- **Bonus starter:** Rope

Field Doctor

Wilderness medic. Incredible endurance but slow on the mountain.

- **Stats:** +3 sur, +2 warm, -2 str, -1 agi
- **Hand size:** +1 | **Starting gold:** -1
- **Ability – Triage:** Discard and lose-card penalties cost 1 fewer

card (minimum 1).

- **Bonus starter:** First Aid Kit

Mountain Scout

Reads terrain instinctively.
Travels light but freezes easily.

- **Stats:** +3 nav, +2 agi, -2 warm, -1 sur
- **Starting gold:** +1 | **Hand size:** -1
- **Ability – Reconnaissance:** Gain 1 gold whenever you reveal a new mountain card.
- **Bonus starter:** Trekking Poles

Survivalist

Built for the long haul. Gets lost, but never gives up.

- **Stats:** +3 warm, +2 sur, -2 nav, -1 str

- **Max camps:** +1
- **Ability – Endure:** Skip-turn penalties become "discard 1" instead.
- **Bonus starter:** Thermos

Elite Athlete

Peak physical specimen. Instinct over preparation.

- **Stats:** +2 str, +2 agi, -1 nav, -1 warm
 - **Starting gold:** -1
 - **Ability – Rising to the Challenge:** Gain 1 gold whenever you pass or solve a challenge.
 - **Bonus starter:** Energy Drink
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5. Stat Domains

Five domains govern challenge resolution and card bonuses:

Domain	Governs
strength	Physical force, climbing power, hauling
agility	Balance, dexterity, ice traction
warmth	Cold resistance, weather mitigation
survival	Endurance, resilience, problem-solving
navigation	Terrain reading, route-finding, direction

Each challenge requires 1–2 domains. Only stats in the required domain(s) count toward the total.

6. Card Systems

6.1 Starter Deck (10 cards)

Every player begins with the same 10-card deck (minus 1 removed card, plus their background bonus):

- **7× Basic Footwork** (cost 0, tool)
 - +1 agility. The foundation of all movement.
- **3× Food Rations** (cost 1, utility)
 - +1 survival. On play: draw 1 card.

6.2 Tool Cards (15 in shop pool)

Durable gear. Some have **durability** – a use count before the card is spent.

Card	Cost	Key Stats	Effect
Rope	2	+2 str	Discard to cancel one fall
Ice Axe	3	+3 str, +1 agi	+1 str on ice/crevasse
Crampons	2	+2 agi	Passive: never fall from ice
Carabiner Set	2	+1 str, +1 agi	Another player on your slot uses its stats
Helmet	2	+2 sur	Passive: discard penalties cost 1 fewer
Trekking Poles	1	+1 agi, +1 nav	—

Card	Cost	Key Stats	Effect
Piton Set	3	+2 str	Your solve counts for all players on slot
Snow Shovel	2	+1 str	On play: remove a weather challenge
Headlamp	1	+2 nav	—
Map & Compass	2	+3 nav	On play: peek next 2 unrevealed cards
Fixed Line	4	+2 str, +2 agi	All players on slot get +1 agi
Tent	3	+2 warm, +1 sur	On play: draw 1 extra card next turn

Card	Cost	Key Stats	Effect
Snow Goggles	2	+1 warm, +1 agi	Passive: weather thresholds -1
Avalanche Beacon	3	+3 sur	On fall: respawn 1 slot above nearest camp
Portaledge	4	+2 sur, +1 warm	On play: gain 2 gold

6.3 Skill Cards (10 in shop pool)

Expertise. Permanent skills remain in play after use.

Card	Cost	Key Stats	Type	Effect
Experienced Climber	4	+1 str, +1 agi	Passive	+1 to your climb stat
Ice Craft	3	+2 agi	Passive	+2 to ice, snow, crevasse
Summit Fever	3	+2 str	Active	Move extra 100m (must be up)
Route Finding	3	+2 nav	Passive	Auto find all navigable routes
Risk Assessment	4	+2 sur	Passive	See hazards before deciding to go

Card	Cost	Key Stats	Type	Effect
Endurance Training	3	+1 str, +1 sur	Passive	Hand +1
Cold Adaptation	3	+2 warm	Passive	Weather threat -2
Technical Climber	4	+2 str, +2 agi	Active	Auto one weather challenge
Mountain Sense	3	+1 nav, +1 sur	Passive	Reveal next unrecovered carcass turn
Iron Will	5	+3 sur	Passive	Resist just discontinue 2 cards

6.4 Utility Cards (10 in shop pool)

Consumables and reusable supplies.
Most are one-time use.

Card	Cost	Key Stats	Effect
Food Rations	1	+1 sur	Draw 1 card
First Aid Kit	2	+2 sur	Remove respawning status
Energy Drink	1	+1 agi, +1 str	Gain 1 extra action
Thermos	1	+2 warm	— (reusable)
Emergency Bivouac	3	+2 warm, +2 sur	Prevent next fall (one-time)
Protein Bar	1	+1 str	Gain 1 gold

Card	Cost	Key Stats	Effect
Altitude Pills	2	+2 sur	Ignore elevation condition challenges this turn
Signal Flare	2	+1 sur	+3 survival vs animal challenges only
Rope Repair Kit	2	—	Restore durability on a spent tool card
Signal Mirror	1	+1 nav	Reveal next unrevealed mountain card

7. Challenge Cards (12 types)

Challenges occupy slots on mountain location cards. When a player moves up onto a card with an active challenge, they must attempt it. Challenges are removed permanently when solved.

Resolution Formula

$$\text{Total} = \text{baseStats}[\text{domains}] + \text{card stats}[\text{domains}] + \text{passive skill bonuses}[\text{domains}]$$

- $\text{Total} \geq \text{Solve threshold} \rightarrow \text{SOLVE}$
(challenge removed, reward granted)
- $\text{Solve} > \text{Total} \geq \text{Pass threshold} \rightarrow \text{PASS}$ (survive, challenge remains)

- **Total < Pass threshold** → FAIL
(penalty applies)

Challenge Table

Card	Type	Domains	Pass	Score
Whiteout Blizzard	Weather	warmth, nav	4	8
Thin Ice	Terrain	agi, str	3	7
Altitude Sickness	Condition	survival	3	6
Angry Mountain Goat	Animal	str, agi	3	5
Rockfall	Terrain	agility	2	5
Crevasse Gap	Terrain	str, agi	4	7
Sudden Storm	Weather	warmth	3	6

Card	Type	Domains	Pass	Score
Frostbite Risk	Condition	warm, sur	4	7
Unstable Seracs	Terrain	agi, nav	5	9
Exhaustion	Condition	sur, str	4	7
Ice Storm	Weather	warm, agi	5	10
Snow Leopard	Animal	sur, agi	3	6

Fail Penalty Types

Penalty	Effect	Background Exceptions
Fall	Respawn at nearest camp below	Mountaineer: terrain falls → discard 1 instead

Penalty	Effect	Background Exceptions
Discard X	Lose X cards from hand	Doctor: -1 minimum 1
Skip Turn	Next move phase skipped	Survivalist: → discard 1 instead
Lose Card X	Permanently remove X cards	Doctor: -1 minimum 1

8. Turn Structure

Each turn has four sequential phases: **Play** → **Move** → **Buy** → **End**

Play Phase

- Play any number of cards from hand

- Skill cards marked Permanent enter the **Active Skills** pile (persist between turns)
- Non-permanent cards go to the discard pile
- Card effects resolve immediately (gold, draw, extra actions)

Move Phase

- Move ± 1 elevation (up or down)
- Cannot exceed board bounds
- Cannot enter a full location unless initiating a Jostle
- Moving up **reveals** unrevealed cards
- Moving up onto a challenged location **triggers challenge resolution**
- A player who reaches elevation 19 wins immediately

Buy Phase

- Spend accumulated gold (turn gold + stored gold) on shop cards
- Purchased cards go directly to discard pile
- Shop refills from the draw pile

End Phase

- Discard non-permanent cards from hand
- Permanent skills remain active
- Draw to hand size for the next player
- Turn gold resets to 0

9. Economy (Gold)

Gold is the primary resource for purchasing cards from the shop.

- **Sources:** card effects (Portaledge +2, Protein Bar +1), challenge solve rewards, background abilities (Reconnaissance, Rising to the Challenge)
 - **Costs:** card purchase costs range from 0 (Basic Footwork) to 5 (Iron Will)
 - **Storage:** gold not spent in the Buy phase carries over as stored gold
 - **Jostle cost:** configurable per game setup
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10. Camp System

Camps are persistent structures placed on mountain locations.

- **Placement:** Buy phase only, on any `allowsCamp` location where no camp

exists

- **Ownership:** Each player can place 1 camp (Survivalist: 2 camps)
 - **Function:** Respawn anchor – if a player falls, they respawn at their nearest camp below
 - **Stash:** Each camp has a stash of cards. Owner may deposit/retrieve freely. Other players may loot once per turn.
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11. Jostle (Player vs. Player)

When a player wants to move to a full location:

1. Player pays the Jostle cost in gold
2. They choose a target player on that location

3. **Iron Will check:** target may spend 2 cards to resist and stay in place
 4. If jostle resolves: target is moved down 1 elevation (minimum Base Camp)
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12. Respawn / Fall

When a player falls:

1. Player is marked as **Respawning**
2. At end of the current turn, they teleport to their nearest camp below current position
3. If no camp exists below them, they return to **Base Camp Alpha** (elevation 0)
4. **Avalanche Beacon exception:**
Respawn 1 slot above the nearest camp instead

13. Win Condition

First player to reach The Summit (elevation 19) wins.

The Summit has only 1 space – only one player can stand there. The game ends the moment any player's move lands them at elevation 19.

14. Shop

Five cards are displayed face-up at all times. When a card is purchased, it is replaced from the draw pile. The shop pool contains all Tool, Skill, and Utility cards shuffled together.

15. Setup

1. Each player chooses a background
2. Each player builds their 10-card starter deck (7× Basic Footwork + 3× Food Rations), removes 1 Basic Footwork, adds their background bonus card
3. All players begin at Base Camp Alpha (elevation 0)
4. Mountain cards are placed (all unrevealed except elevation 0)
5. Shop is populated with 5 cards face-up
6. Play order is determined; youngest player goes first